amber skies

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/32196526.

Rating:
Not Rated

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

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Multi

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Angella/Micah (She-Ra), Angella & Catra (She-Ra), Catra & Micah (She-Ra)

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Angella (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra)

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Catra (She-Ra) Redemption, Catra Needs Therapy (She-Ra), Catra Leaves the Horde (She-Ra), Fluff, Family Bonding, there is SLIGHT angst but not much, this may be the least angst I've posted <3, essentially exile but from angellas POV, imagine being queen and your not-dead husband comes back, except he brought an angsty teen with him, and you already had ONE angsty teen

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Part 4 of evermore

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by aswellingstorm

Summary

It is with great trepidation that Angella allows her daughter and her friends to rescue the former Horde commander from Beast Island. The very last thing that the Queen expects from this mission is for her family to double in size.

or;

Set during exile; bits and pieces of Angella's perspective.

Notes

the text after the second break is (abridged) but lifted directly from ch 9 of hoax but fit the narrative pretty well here! enjoy

See the end of the work for more notes

so clever

Angella is careful. Calculated. Perhaps a bit cold, depending on who you asked.

And letting one Horde soldier into their ranks had been bold enough. Only feasible, really, because that soldier had turned out to be *She-Ra* . But a rescue mission to retrieve a disgraced and fallen second-in-command? Especially one who had harmed her own daughter? The thought is absolutely absurd.

However, her calculations have determined that even if this *Catra* were to prove to be nothing more than a hostile prisoner, the Rebellion is still better off for assisting Scorpia and expanding their alliances.

She also knows her daughter and her friends well enough by this point to know when an argument is fraught. Even if she had overruled the vote and vetoed the idea, she has a fairly strong feeling that Adora would've taken off on the mission on her own.

Ultimately, this Beast Island mission is for the best. She waits until Glimmer and her crew depart before allowing herself a small, fond smile.

Micah would be so proud of their daughter. She's certainly got his spark. And for far too long, Angella has tried to contain that spark, shield it from the wind and hold it close.

But perhaps it's time to let that spark fan into a flame. To allow her daughter to step into her own power and trust that she and her friends will only bring them closer to defeating the Horde.

The world stops spinning on its axis and comes to a complete standstill when the crew returns.

The first person Angella sees is Catra. Her eyebrows raise to an unimpressed stare when she realizes the girl is not handcuffed or

restrained in any way--but she quickly realizes that not only is she *asleep* , she is also fairly bloodied and bruised.

She looks so small. Far smaller than Angella could recall from quick battlefield glances. And far smaller than she anticipated based on the stories she has heard from Glimmer or the rest of the Alliance. Has she always been this small? Was it merely the tales of her bluster that took up so much room?

Her eyes soften at the sight of Catra, curled up and carried across the courtyard.

It strikes Angella very suddenly that this former leader of the Horde is no older than her own daughter. Hordak may be known as the indisputable leader of the Horde, but it is no secret that Catra has been orchestrating all offensive measures.

For the first time, Angella realizes she has been waging a war against a *child* .

She is so transfixed on Catra that she does not pay much mind to the person carrying her. Until they turn and place her in Scorpia's arms with a whisper of a voice that sounds just so slightly familiar.

It is a sound that has haunted her many, many times before. She used to hear it in the wind or in the voice of a stranger and let herself have an ounce of foolish, reckless hope. Nothing quite compares to the burn of *hoping* only to be let down time and time again.

But - now feels different. Before, the world would stare expectantly at Angella - waiting for her to move on and live back in the present. Now, she feels everyone's eyes on her and the eager energy from Glimmer feels a little too suspicious to be directed towards the saving of their fallen enemy.

Angella pries her eyes away from Catra, mouth falling open as she takes in the sight before her. Perhaps it is an illusion of some sort - perhaps it is an odd coincidence that this rugged and tired man

who looks *too* much like her long-deceased husband, is standing before her with tears in his eyes.

The necklace that falls squarely on his chest is familiar - Angella would recognize it anywhere. She had gifted it to him as part of the Bright Moon wedding tradition. But there is no way - it is simply not *possible* for Micah to be here now. She has suffered from too much false hope to let herself believe again, until he opens his mouth with all of the confirmation she needs:

"Angie."

One and only one person ever had the gall to shorten her name in such a way. Initial annoyance soon bled way to fondness at the term of endearment, a term she believed she would never hear again.

He is real - he is here, and he is very much *alive* . Shock courses through Angella, burning through her skin like a live wire, but it does not stop her from slowly stepping forward - reaching out her hands and cupping his face in a practiced move.

Real. Here. She can feel the warmth of his skin under her hand and it only takes a mere moment more of tender eye contact before she is crying and he's pulling her into a hug. She does not care if the rest of the Alliance or the guards are watching such an open display of vulnerability because -

After nearly two decades apart, her husband is alive.

She holds him tighter, worried he might just disappear even within her grasp. He assures her he isn't leaving - will never go anywhere again and he is *sorry* for some reason she can't quite comprehend.

Angella is still processing the onslaught of emotions when she finds that the only thing more surprising than her *not*- dead husband returning from his apparent exile is the fact that he has acquired a particular friend along the way.

“She’s not a bad kid. She just...got dealt a bad hand. Grew up too quick. Got a little lost along the way.”

Micah looks at Angella with such blazing sincerity that she knows there’s no force in all of Greater Etheria that will sway her husband from his decision. Not that she was trying to. There’s much to catch her husband up on--and she’s still reeling from her fact that he’s even here. Alive. After nearly two decades of exile.

She looks down to the girl in question, sleeping soundly on the bed in the room they’ve made up for her. Catra has managed to be both a large, looming threat while also remaining faceless to Angella. And now, after a wildly successful rescue mission, she is here, primarily at peace on Bright Moon grounds.

Angella can see how correct her husband is right now-Catra is just a child. But, child or not, every action is accompanied by consequence. And Catra has accrued quite a debt to the Alliance at large.

“The deal was that she either join the Alliance upon her return or be held as a prisoner here,” Angella restates, not unkindly.

But Micah shakes his head fervently, “Angie, we can’t. If we force her into something, she’ll just close up-”

“I understand she’s young, but that does not excuse her past actions against the Alliance. She has kidnapped our daughter, attacked Bright Moon, led countless operations against the Rebellion,” Angella lists, more than prepared to continue on.

She is weary. Rightfully so. His steadfast advocacy for Catra would hold a bit more weight if he wasn’t so weathered and worn from his time on the island himself.

“I understand that. And I...I know it’s hard to believe, but we know very different versions of her. When we first met, she went out of her way to bring me food rations and…” Micah explains, “She never even expected a thank-you. She’s saved my life, twice,

and I know she may act like she doesn't care, but that's really all it is: an act."

"Really?" Angella challenges as they continue to speak in hushed tones, "You expect me to believe that upon your first interaction, she'd instantly taken a liking to you?"

"Uh. Well. Not quite," Micah mutters, "The first interaction was...not great. But after I saved her from getting attacked by Pookas, everything changed. She started to open up more. She stuck around, offered to help me get off of the island. She was trying to offer me a way out, to get back home to her enemies and expected nothing in return. She didn't even want to come with me, Angie."

It is...hard to reconcile this image of her with the tales relayed by Glimmer. Even Shadow Weaver herself seems to be in remiss of the force she had created through her own callous actions.

And yet, she looks so peaceful now. A little damaged from escaping the island, of course. Micah must've casted some sort of rune to keep her asleep for their return. The queen would never admit it out loud but part of her heart softens the slightest bit as Catra grumbles something incoherent in her sleep.

She wants to believe her husband. And if what he's saying is true, it coincides with Adora and Scorpia's impassioned beliefs that Catra can change her ways. She cannot allow herself to be so naive though, so openly trusting and optimistic.

However, if he is correct, she cannot suppress a flare of anger with Shadow Weaver. The nerve of that woman to seek refuge here and make herself out to be the victim when she was the one truly at fault.

Anger, also for herself. If it is possible that Catra is not the threatening, poised-for-great-evil commander that Angella had previously believed...she must admit culpability for not intervening sooner. She was a child born into the Horde. Brainwashed from

her first breaths by a castigatory entity that has only existed because she had never been able to defeat them.

“If one act of kindness can open up this...entire side of her,” Micah theorizes, “Imagine what could happen now? If we offer her a clean slate, a new start away from the place and the people who’ve hurt her? If we extend a bit of forgiveness?”

“Hmm,” she hums her assent, brow furrowing as she observes Catra. Wondering if she stares hard enough, she’ll receive an answer on the girl’s morality.

“Angella, we can’t punish her or make her into a prisoner,” Micah pleads.

“Back for less than a day and you already resumed your belief that Alliance meetings are that great of a punishment?” Her tone is airy, teasing. Avoiding the direct request.

“Just...give me some time,” Micah requests, “I’m not saying she should have free reign over the castle, but if she really wanted to sabotage the Rebellion, she would’ve already. If I can just work with her a bit more, I’m sure we can figure out a way for her to help even if it’s not directly through the Alliance.”

Angella smiles at him softly. She has missed his stubbornness. Then she glances back at Catra, who’s turned her head to the side of the wall. At this angle, Angella can see scars, bruises that have nearly faded around her neck. She swallows thickly, remembering Glimmer and Bow’s recounts of what they had endured in their brief time in the Fright Zone after the Princess Prom.

That had only been for a short period of time. Angella can’t fathom what staying there for a lifetime would be like.

“So long as you have no plans on departing again,” Angella frames in an even voice, “I will give you all the time you require.”

“I’m never leaving again,” He tells her, eyes supporting his promise with blazing sincerity.

"I'll hold you to that," She takes a deep breath, lacing her arm through his as they turn to head out of the room quietly.

"You know," Micah proposes after the door shuts silently behind them, "I think you two might actually get along."

"Oh, don't worry darling," Angella smiles softly, "I intend to put that theory to the test."

Unfortunately, it would seem that Catra does not want much to do with anyone other than Micah. The walls in Bright Moon are not quite so thick, and Angella is very aware of the ample amount of grumbling and complaining that even her husband endures from her.

She is careful to keep her distance. If Catra is so insistent on rejecting any olive branches from her former best friend, Angella is skeptical she'd be willing to speak with the very agent she's been raised to despise.

Besides, Adora has informed her that the Horde posters and projections of her are *not* at all flattering.

Regardless, Angella is more than content to stand back and observe. Keeping a careful eye on the former Horde soldier. Part of her is suspicious that the girl is up to something and that her husband should *not* be trying to teach her magic but...it makes him so happy. Anytime Catra opens up even the slightest bit to him or shares in his interest for magical texts, his eyes light up.

It is a sort of happiness that is infectious in a way. Micah didn't get to watch Glimmer grow up or see her magic mature or strengthen over the last few years. Getting to *try* with Catra, even if the efforts haven't amounted to much just yet, allows her husband to reclaim a small piece of parenthood that had been stolen from him by Shadow Weaver.

He truly takes great joy in showing Catra things that she had not previously known before. Angella thinks it is helpful for him to

reacclimate to life back in Bright Moon. Teaching someone else often helps reinforce ones own knowledge and every day Micah spends with Catra, the more he becomes the man Angella remembers marrying.

And the more stories she hears from Micah about his time spent with Catra - be it on Beast Island or in the library, the more her own intrigue grows. Surely the child has retained all of her sarcastic attitude and fiery spirit, that much is clear, but even as Angella keeps a watchful eye on the girl from across the courtyard she can see it - every day, little by little, the walls are coming down. She is changing. Relaxing a bit.

Her apprehension for the girl has melted into curiosity. Angella can admit that she largely doesn't quite understand Catra. Isn't she meant to be the ruthless Horde commander who valued victory more than anything?

She begins to question if that is what Catra ever truly wanted.

If victory is all she ever wanted,her adjustment to Bright Moon doesn't make much sense. She hasn't tried to leave or stir up trouble. She prefers to be left alone for the most part.

The Horde has taken away her chance of winning, more than the Rebellion has, but she hasn't turned that betrayal into a craving desire for revenge against them.

It's stupefying - Catra isn't quite what Angella expected. Not at all.

Angella decides it's time for her to spend a bit of each day with Catra and Micah, during their walks around Bright Moon. Evidently, the addition of the queen is unnerving for Catra. She's rather reserved in her presence, posture straight and jaw tight. Like she has to make certain she's on her best behavior.

If Catra weren't within earshot, Angella might just laugh. No one else acts quite so formal with her--guards aside. Even Adora has relaxed around her.

But such rigidity isn't funny, not when Angella realizes the source is less from titular respect and more from fear.

Not all of the stories Micah relays to her are pleasant, after all.

"I should've stopped Shadow Weaver *years* ago," Micah laments one evening, after dinner when they've returned to their room.

"You tried dear," Angella reminds him, "That's how you ended up in exile."

"I know but...what she did to me," Micah sighs, "It's just a drop in the ocean compared to all of the damage she's done after me."

It doesn't make Micah's scars any less valid. She tells him as much, "You can acknowledge that other people may have had worse experiences, but still wish you had better for yourself."

Her words seem to bring him some sense of comfort. But Angella does not rest easy that night. Not after hearing more of the intricate details of Catra's relationships with Shadow Weaver and Hordak.

Catra is more than a former Force Captain. She may be grown now, but she is a child who was forced to maturity far too quickly. Coerced into playing high-stakes games without ever knowing the personal toll. She is a child who adapted to a toxic environment with sharpened skill by building walls adorned with poisonous spikes meant to keep everyone out.

While such defensive mechanisms protected her at the time and are likely the very reason she survived, it is time for those walls to come down and more adaptive measures to be constructed in their place.

Angella sees an opening one evening.

She's surprised she hasn't thought of it sooner—a celebration to mark the return of her husband. And who better to plan it other

than the former Horde strategist who saved him?

For all of Catra's eye rolling and complaining, it's rather obvious that she has come to care quite a bit for Micah, so Angella has no doubt that she will readily agree to the opportunity. It's not like Catra has much on her plate after her staunch refusal to join the Rebellion time and time again, anyway.

She's been planning on asking all day, meeting up with Micah and Catra after their training to insist they all share dinner to discuss. However, it appears as though there was a... *heated* situation in the library and Catra has been holed up in her room ever since.

Fire. Of course the girl forged under the heat and ire of the Fright Zone would be able to wield *fire.*

It's so fitting that Angella smiles a bit to herself as she makes her way down the hallway to Catra's room.

It really couldn't hurt to balance out their elemental forces with a bit of heat, either. But Angella figures that is a conversation for another day. If she can get Catra to agree to organizing the celebration, there will be a bit more wiggle room for her to campaign for the Rebellion. Perhaps integrating Catra with other people, guards, civilians, *herself* , will show her that there is much to fight for in this war.

The guards stationed outside of her room cast a nervous glance to Angella.

"Catra has refused his majesty several times this afternoon," One of them informs her after greeting.

"I appreciate the warning, but I am not my husband," Angella responds with a playful glint in her eye, boldly knocking on the door for herself.

Immediately she is greeted with muffled grumbling. The sound of a petulant cry, "You're so *annoying!* " comes through the crack under the door.

Angella is already smirking to herself, certain the words cannot be intended for her. Her smile only grows when Catra opens the door to her room, looking appropriately gobsmacked - floored by the Queen's presence.

Catra grumbles something under her breath, but opens the door to let Angella in regardless. She seems a little on edge - more so than her usual demeanor. Angella wonders if this is a consequence of Adora's valiant attempts to rekindle their friendship, well aware of how strong the girl can come off at times.

"He can be quite stubborn, can't he?" Angella tries - perhaps bringing up Micah is the best way to broach the conversation.

Still, Catra looks rather unnerved. "Pfft. Um. Yeah. That's kind of an understatement."

"Such stubbornness…I never thought I'd miss it until it was gone." And it's true. Growing up, Angella had been drawn to his boyish charm and playful antics whenever she caught a glimpse of him running around Mystacor. He'd been the only sorcerer in training who wasn't intimidated by Angella or her parents during their official visits - the only one who ever dared to challenge her.

Angella is swept up in the memory for a moment, and Catra's next words truly surprise her, "He…um. He really missed you, too."

Catra is trying, Angella realizes. Not just *trying* in a general sense, but trying to comfort her. The Queen - the woman she was raised to despise. It breaks Angella's heart in a sort of way because it is only further cementing that she had been wrong about Catra. Clearly, the general could not be all bad if this is what she does, *how she acts* after just a few weeks away from the Horde.

Her husband was right, it would seem. He always was the more optimistic of the pair.

Catra continues to speak, "I mean. He also tried really hard—like stupidly hard to get back to you guys. Like seriously. You should

see some of the things he tried to make just to get off the island. Ask him about his razorfin deflector. Or—”

Angella is certain she must look *motherly* right now, but she can’t help the appreciation she feels for this - this *person* in the castle. The former enemy, the child soldier who was pushed to do far too much and lost her way. She understands Micah now, and she does not find Catra saving her husband to be quite so unthinkable anymore.

“Catra. I didn’t come here to talk about my husbands…interesting knack for innovation. Or lack thereof.”

Catra averts her gaze, arm hooking over her elbow. Angella can see her shrink in on herself reconstruct the walls in right before her eyes. “Right…Actually, I was just—"

Before it can reach that point, Angella tries for a lighthearted joke. With her hands intertwined behind her back and shoulders relaxed, she looks around the room, “You know, I haven’t been in this room in quite some time. It might be in need of some redecorating.”

“Redecorating?” Catra asks, not following.

“Yes. However, I assume you’ll let me know in advance should you ever try to make any changes.” She says with a smirk. When Catra still looks confused, she elaborates, “You know—seeing as you had such an issue with the layout of the library you felt it necessary to start a small fire, today.”

“I-uh-listen,” Catra shifts backwards, scrambling to put some space between then, “That was—I know. It doesn’t sound like it, but that was an accident—”

However, the joke most certainly does *not* land - much to Angella’s horror.

She knows for a fact that Micah has joked with Catra before, typically landing an annoyed-yet-amused reaction, but perhaps

they aren’t quite there yet in their relationship.

“Oh, Catra, no. I was simply joking.”

It is understandable, Angella realizes as she explains the true sentiment behind her words. Hordak may have been cruel to Catra, but he did not leave as nearly as many scars as Shadow Weaver herself. It is only fair that her bond with Micah is easier, more natural. There is a slight pang in Angella’s heart as Catra continues to look genuinely fearful.

“Forgive me. Micah, as you can see, is far better at this than I am,” Angella attempts to comfort.

“I didn’t mean to.” Catra tells her, looking earnest - but not expecting to be believed.

And in that moment, it isn’t Catra she sees. It is Glimmer - just as a child, having knocked over some vase that was a family heirloom - an item Angella had personally never cared much for. She heard a crash from down the hall and ran over to it in fear that Glimmer had been hurt. Instead she found her daughter in tears, apologizing and saying it was an accident.

How very sad it is that Glimmer was worried some nameless family possession would mean more to Angella than her own *daughter* . She had just been relieved her daughter was okay - but the fear in her eyes, the genuine remorse, is something that has stuck with Angella.

She is snapped back to the present moment by Catra, “I don’t want to hurt people anymore! I don't—I don’t want this. Okay? And I’m not going to—do anything with it.”

Angella reels back a bit, blinking in surprise. “With what? Your power?”

“Yes, the whole fire thing! What else?”

Her and Glimmer are *so* very similar. Angella briefly worries for the state of the castle, should the two of them ever get along for more than five seconds.

"You're upset…because you can conjure fire?" She presses.

"Fire is bad! Obviously." Catra snaps, still wholly uninterested in meeting Angella's gaze. It strikes Angella that magic must be incredibly polarizing for Catra. Her only real experiences with it come from Shadow Weaver - who had manifested only harm, and Adora - whose magic was so light and good and pure that it pulled her from the Horde. "And—conjure, is a little dramatic. I don't even know how I did it! I just know Adora was pissing me off and then…boom. I'm not like you or Glimmer. Whatever magic I have, it's dark and it's messed up and it doesn't…doesn't come from a good place."

"Hmm," Angella looks around the room, finding one of the standard Bright Moon guest hair brushes laying on the floor. The only time she had really seen Catra was with that mask on, and she is guessing that managing her hair without it has been another source of frustration. Angella *had* heard a bit banging on her way over here.

She believes Catra doesn't want to hurt people anymore. If she truly wanted to, she would have already. Would never let her husband in or have tried to make amends with Scorpia.

A different approach crosses Angella's mind as she reaches down to pick up the hair brush.

Angella's own parents were never quite on sight. Anyone who knew them would never accuse Angella of being *cold* or distant - never in the way they were. But if there are any fond memories she has of her mother, it would be the days when she set aside just a bit of time to brush through her hair - put it in a bun or maybe even an intricate braid. It was it's own sort of comfort, peace.

As she thinks, she makes an offhand comment about Adora. Catra blushes and stammers her way around it, only looking more caught off guard when Angella asks her to take a seat. She does so begrudgingly, Angella picks up on the silent fear. Her own heart falls when Catra *flinches* at her just raising the hair brush in the mirror.

The queen had her suspicions about the treatment of child soldiers in the Horde, but now she was beginning to believe the treatment Catra had endured under Shadow Weaver to be downright inconceivable. Perhaps even worse than Micah knows.

"May I?" Angella asks, trying to keep her voice soft and gentle. She won't be disappointed no matter how Catra responds - she simply wants to help. Not increase any sort of anxiety she may be feeling.

Catra nods slowly but her apprehension is clear. Angella takes extra caution and care while brushing through Catra's hair - serenely explaining the mechanisms and morality of magic. This is a topic she is comfortable with, this is a *task* she is comfortable with. Perhaps she cannot offer advice or comfort in the same way as Micah, but she can explain freedom of choice and detangle any knots along the way. Gradually, she notices Catra begin to relax as she passes along some anecdotes of her husband.

Angella never wore her hair up - it simply wasn't her style - but she always kept the band from her mother around her wrist. A little sparkling reminder of the fleeting happy moments they shared together. However, she suspects there is a better use for it now.

She finishes her work by pulling Catra's hair to the back of her head. She isn't *Adora* and Angella knows she doesn't like her style to be very tight-knit, so she makes sure to leave a few pieces out to frame Catra's face. The rest she secures in a low ponytail with the band from her mother, smiling as she takes in Catra's reaction. It is silent awe, a bit overwhelming she is sure, but it earns her a moment of genuine gratitude.

"Thanks," Catra tells her, and Angella is beyond satisfied with herself. With a pleased smile, Angella presses a gentle squeeze to Catra's shoulders before making her way to the door.

Angella nearly *leaves* before she remembers the point of this journey, "Oh! I almost forgot why I came in here. I have an important job for you, Catra. Should you choose to accept it."

Catra's face falls into utter exasperation, "Ugh. Fine! I'll join the Rebellion. I'm so tired of everyone asking!"

A great smile breaks across her face at Catra's response. That was *not* her question, not at all - but she knows better than to look a gift horse in the mouth.

She tells Catra of her plans for the celebration instead, which the girl readily agrees to.

"But—I'm glad I've gotten you to agree to joining the Rebellion as well," She simply cannot wait to relay the news to her husband. He's been so dismayed by Catra closing herself off again, so this will certainly cheer him up.

"No—wait! I didn't—that's not—" Catra attempts to argue, but it is in vain.

"Two birds, as they say," Angella sighs happily, "See you bright and early for tomorrow's meeting. 9 AM, sharp!"

She closes the door, flickers off the fight as she always does whenever she says goodnight to Glimmer, and smiles broadly.

Both an incredible stroke of luck and a great step forward.

The Rebellion meeting introducing Catra as an ally had gone well. *Too* well, Angella thinks. There had been some discontentment among the members, but that was to be expected.

“I really think she’s beginning to get acclimated to Bright Moon,” Micah says as they approach the throne room. “I mean, I honestly didn’t expect her to even be open to joining for another month at the very least.”

Angella smiles brightly back at him. She knows progress with Catra is typically slow-going but unfailingly substantial. Each step forward, no matter how small, is true progress. And she knows her husband well enough to know that he has a *plan* in place - a timed journey to demonstrate a world outside of the Horde to Catra.

“You’ll have to call George and Lance,” she tells him teasingly, “They always seem to enjoy your updates on Catra.”

“So long as I leave out the parts about her bullying their son,” He says with a laugh. “But honestly - can you believe it? Just two weeks ago I couldn’t even get her out of her room. She beat *us* to the meeting today.”

Angella’s heart feels light in a way it never quite did in all of the years of her husband's absence. Such lightheartedness gives her pause - fear it could all be taken away, but if there is one thing she learned over the last two decades, it is to let herself enjoy the moments she *does* have. “Mhm, and that says a lot, seeing as you were so eager to see if she would show up that you got us there early.”

Micah shakes his head with a fond smile, “She’s even coming around to Perfuma now, too. I think we’re you know - *really* doing this.”

“We?” Angella questions, “Dear, I have to default all of the credit to you.”

“Come on, Angie,” he raises a brow, “I don’t think she would’ve agreed if it weren’t for you.”

Angella presses her lips into a thin line, much less amused by this fact, “It is only because she is so unnerved by me, I’m afraid.”

Micah’s eyes soften, “She’ll come around. We just have to show her she can trust us.”

Angella is *fine* with that. She has always been the more patient of the two of them. She is about to voice her support when she is greeted by the sight of Glimmer teleporting into the room, grabbing her friend -

No, not a friend. *Catra* .

Glimmer is clearly riled up, hand wrapped tight around Catra’s ponytail - the latter appearing as though she is all of two seconds away from swiping at Glimmer.

And, well, Angella did have a sinking suspicion that the morning had been going too smoothly.

“Guys, look!” Glimmer says breathlessly, “I *told* you she was up to something!”

Angella closes her eyes and takes a deep inhale, “Glimmer, release Catra at *once* .” When she opens her eyes, they are boring heatedly into her daughters.

“But,” Glimmer tries to explain, accidentally tugging on Catra’s hair - earning a hiss and some squirming.

“Now, Glimmer.” Angella grits out - patience wearing thin for her daughter.

Glimmer has, unmistakably, had the *hardest* time adjusting to Catra's presence out of anyone on Bright Moon. Angella thought at first it might be due to fears of losing Adora's attention to her childhood best friend - but Catra has made it *very* clear that will not be an issue.

Glimmer is jealous of Catra's relationship with someone else entirely.

With a sigh, Angella knows she cannot blame Glimmer. Glimmer lost her father - only holding onto the littlest pieces of childhood memories. Now that she has him back but has to share? Sharing has never quite been a strong suit for Glimmer.

But Micah makes a great effort to balance his time between Glimmer and Catra - the latter of which is never demanding of his time or energy. In fact Catra is rather apprehensive about overstepping. Oftentimes she cuts the time between her and Micah short if she can sense Glimmer's impatience or feelings as though she is infringing.

Still, Angella wills herself to be empathetic with her daughter - sharing the familiarity of her pain of losing Micah.

Eventually, Glimmer relents her hold on Catra, and Angella exhales a sigh of relief before exchanging a weary glance with Micah.

"Now, Catra," Angella starts over Glimmer's loudening protests, "Are you alright?"

Catra rights herself before looking between the three of them with mild irritation, "Uh, yeah? I mean - I'd be a whole lot better if Sparkles over here didn't *attack* me."

"I didn't attack you!" Glimmer argues, voice shrill.

"Funny, we must have different definitions of the word," Catra snarks.

“Oh really?” Glimmer challenges. Micah looks a little lost on how to handle this situation, but Angella offers the chance to let him take lead. “How do *you* define it? Cause you seemed to understand the concept pretty well when you were leading the Horde and trying to destroy Bright Moon!”

Catra hisses at that, “Clearly I didn’t try hard enough if you’re still here - ”

“Girls, enough.” Micah says authoritatively. They both quiet down - crossing their arms and looking away from each other. “Thank you. Now - can someone explain what exactly is happening here?”

Glimmer speaks first, “Catra is *stealing* from us! I told you - Horde scum doesn’t change!”

“What are you talking about?” Catra turns around to face her, voice incredulous and face flushed with embarrassment at the accusation. “I haven’t taken any of your shi- *stuff!* And if I did, what would I even do with it?”

“I don’t know! You tell me!” Glimmer huffs before grabbing Catra’s shoulders and turning her around.

“Stop touching me!” Catra growls.

“See!” Glimmer points to the back of Catra’s head, “She *stole* your hair band! And isn’t it - didn’t it belong to Grandma?”

In order to hold on to her reserve of patience, Angella sighs deeply and pinches the bridge of her nose. Of course - of all the heirlooms and items that she has passed down to Glimmer over the years, the *one* that she hasn’t is the one that Glimmer has kept a sharp eye on.

Catra looks a little bit helpless - a little bit *betrayed* by Angella. The older woman knows - assumes Catra is feeling as though she’s been set up.

She decides to clear the air quickly, "Catra did not steal the hair band. I gifted it to her. Yes, it was your grandmother's - but then it was mine, and now it is hers."

Catra frowns, "I didn't know that -"

"Are you serious?" Glimmer demands.

"Glimmer, I do *not* have the patience for this," Angella warns, "Unless you have any other items that you falsely believe Catra has taken, then I suggest we drop this."

"But - "

"Immediately." She insists, before looking over to where Catra stands - awkwardly looking away, almost as though she wishes the floor would open up and swallow her whole. "And I believe you owe Catra an *apology* ."

Glimmer gapes at her for a minute, before landing on a similarly-betrayed expression. She groans before bellowing, "I'm tired of this! You two always defend her!"

"They're not defending me," Catra bristles and levels Glimmer with a glare, "You were just wrong."

Angella is grateful that Catra sticks up for herself, at the very least. Micah seems even less pleased with Glimmer's behavior than she does herself.

Matters are made worse when Glimmer presents an ultimatum, "I'm serious. It's either her or me."

This is where her daughter *exasperates* her. There is no choice that is necessary to make, and there has been no sacrifice or overly extensive strain on Glimmer's behalf - she just wants things to be entirely *her* way, and that simply will not do.

Angella understands missing Micah, understands wanting to make up for lost time - but this is not the proper way to do so. Her

husband is not a commodity that has to be divided and parsed amongst them equally. Glimmer is going to have to learn to coexist with Catra.

If Catra looked uncomfortable before, there is no word to capture how miserable she looks in this moment. Eyes downcast and already anticipating a rejection. Angella doesn't even need to look at Micah to know they are on the same wavelength.

"Glimmer. Stop acting like a child." Angella keeps her voice stern and steady, all the while knowing it will do little to deter her.

Micah voices his support, "We aren't doing this. There's no need for us to choose between either of you."

Glimmer argues petulantly," *Yes* there is—"

"Glimmer, enough! We aren't playing this game with you." Micah interrupts firmly. Angella untenses just a bit in appreciation for the fact she no longer has to go through these arguments with Glimmer alone.

"Really? So, you won't choose?" Glimmer asks - tears swelling in her eyes. It hurts Angella in the same way it always does to see her daughter upset, but she knows she cannot waver on this matter.

The air is tense when both Angella and Micah shake their heads in refusal. Catra doesn't seem to relax at their denial at all, if anything she seems even more on-guard.

"Alright. I'm done with this," She huffs before she turns and stalks out of the room.

Glimmer isn't too far behind her - departing with another threat of defiance, "Fine. But just so you know, not making a choice *is* a choice!"

When the door slams behind her, Angella fully exhales and pinches the bridge of her nose, wings drooping slightly at her

slides. She loves Glimmer to death and back but she can be so frustrating.

“That could have gone better,” Micah sighs.

“It has gone a lot worse,” Angella assures him, “Trust me.”

“I should probably go talk to Catra,” He sighs with a disappointed shake of his head.

When he makes a move to leave, Angella stops him with a hand on his arm. “Wait. Give her a moment to herself.”

Micah looks surprised at the gesture, but accepts her direction with a solemn nod. They’ll have to have a long talk later about what to do next with Glimmer - but for now, Angella sighs and worries about what to do with their new battle strategist and event coordinator.

Progress does not occur in massive breakthroughs or earth-shattering relizations. There are miniscule steps that allow Angella to get to know Catra and, in turn, allow Catra to relax bit by bit in her presence.

She learns that Catra has the same act-first-think-later attitude as her daughter, but only when it comes to matters of the heart. In battle planning, she takes care in calculating the next move but when it comes with *emotions* , she acts with an overabundance of haste. It is an immediate reaction, heated and burning and defensive. All of this is evidenced by any interactions between Catra and Adora.

Additionally, Angella finds that Catra is rather funny. She is used to a life of people acting so cautiously around her and other nobility; taking great care to ensure no offense has been dealt. Catra, however, does not seem to care much for these formalities, at least with Micah. Or even Glimmer, now that the two have put their differences aside - much to the dismay of kitchen staff.

And where Glimmer is eager and agreeable and energetic, Catra is calm, poised and perhaps a bit snarky. It's a funny balance - to watch her husband suggest something he believes to be *fun* , such as ice fishing in the Kingdom of the Snows, and see Glimmer try to mask her true emotions for the idea by jumping at the chance to bond with her father.

Whereas Catra doesn't even try to mask her disdain,

"You couldn't even figure out how to fish on an island *surrounded* with bodies of water. You really wanna up the ante by freezing your only water supply?" She questions with an unimpressed brow, never breaking the monotone cadence of her voice or blank stare.

No. Catra does not hide her true opinions. And while she thinks she can put up a facade in other ways, by acting disinterested or unaffected by her friends, Angella can see right through her. See that behind the scars of an ousted, former Horde leader there is someone, hoping to be seen and wanting to have love. Not just love or be loved, but a mutual reciprocation.

And Angella has never been an easy sleeper - but lately her racing thoughts are keeping her up. She is angry, she is remorseful, she is a *lot* of things.

One night it is the anger that rises above all else.

Ghosts of conversations and shelled out sentences ring in her mind - vague allusions Shadow Weaver has made about Catra. About how she is unsafe, dangerous - someone to be feared. Now, Angella seethes not only at herself for being played a fool, but at Shadow Weaver for the sheer audacity.

Perhaps Angella should count her blessings. Catra getting exiled is the reason they found Micah, after all. But she cannot ignore how Shadow Weaver duped her - the child entrusted in her care, and left her for dead. Her blood boils at the thought. They may not be

biologically related, sure, but Shadow Weaver took her in. She had an obligation, a duty that she has failed to live up to.

Angella cannot fathom it.

With tender care, so as to not wake Micah up, she slowly gets out of their bed and makes way for the door. She just needs to *see* the wretched, pathetic excuse of a caretaker for herself. Ask her a question or two -

The light on their nightstand flicks on.

“Angie?” Micah’s voice - tired and raspy from sleep, calls out.

She halts in her tracks - *caught* .

“Go back to sleep dear,” She requests without turning around.

Micah frowns at her, “Is there something wrong? What are you doing up so late?”

“Nothing is wrong,” Angella is quick to respond. “You should get some rest.”

There is a pregnant pause between them, and Angella almost believes her husband has fallen back asleep - perhaps he was never truly awake in the first place, until he speaks again,

“Shadow Weaver isn’t worth it.”

Surprised, Angella turns to face him, but he has a knowing look on his face.

“Think you’re the only one who can’t sleep?” Micah challenges her, a bit playful, but mostly sad. She exhales softly and Micah speaks again, “It won’t do us any good, you know.”

“She just - I cannot believe,” Angella frowns - blaming the early hour and lack of sleep for her inability to finish sentences.

Micah sits up right and holds a hand out to her, “I know.”

“And - Catra - she’s so, she’s just so -” Angella accepts the hand, allowing herself to be pulled back onto the bed. “She’s just a child. And Shadow Weaver…”

It is hard to understand - even harder to verbalize. Angella was never close to her parents, but they never harmed her. She never feared for her safety in their presence and they largely shielded her from the cruelties of the outside world. She may even dare say she was a might too sheltered in that regard - left completely blind sided by the loss of her husband.

“Shadow Weaver was never like this - not when I was growing up,” Micah frowns. “ I might’ve been her favorite, but she still treated the most unskilled sorcerer better than she treated any child in the Horde.”

It is not exactly comforting information to receive. Angella finds herself a little choked up, “I wish... ”

“I know.” And Micah *does* know. Twenty years apart but he still knows her. It is almost alarming, how quickly they’ve regained their rhythm.

They lay back down together and Micah presses a gentle kiss to her shoulder. Emotions storm inside of her, dark gray and disastrous. She is angry, she is sad but...

Mostly - she is determined to show Catra a life her younger self could never even dream of.

“Has anyone seen Adora? Or Catra? I’ve been looking everywhere since this morning and I haven’t been able to find them.”

If Angella had thought her previous night had been restless, nothing truly compares to the evening after hearing Bow’s news.

Angella would fear Catra has run off by herself if she weren’t so certain that could never be a possibility. She has been stressed and, quite frankly, overworking herself. But it isn’t like Catra to

simply run away - she certainly wouldn't now, not after all of the work she's put in.

And it makes even less sense for her to run away with Adora. Sure, their friendship has been on the mend, but it is still tense. Angella highly doubts something momentous enough occurred that would have convinced the two of them to run away *together* .

It means that one of them must be hurt - or has been taken. Hopefully one of them is helping the other and they are sticking together, but Angella is well aware of how tumultuous their relationship has been as of late.

It could also mean that one of them - or both of them, really, are gravely injured and unable to communicate for help.

As the hours tick by and no stone within Bright Moon grounds is left unturned, Angella's fears worsen. Swift Wind should have been able to get a read on Adora by now. The fact he *hasn't* doesn't bode well.

Adora will be fine. She is sturdy, she is *She-Ra* , after all. But Catra has been unwell. Sure, she's been sharpening her magical abilities, but she has far more enemies in this world than friends. Something had to have happened to her, Angella just knows it. Her pacing is likely to leave a hole in the floor, at this rate.

Micah has been dutifully managing search teams - trying to be strategic. Fighting every urge he has to join - but one look at Angella's fear-strained face and he knew he could not leave Bright Moon. It is too soon for him to leave again. It will always be too soon, but -

But thankfully by daybreak, Swift Wind is able to locate them. Adora, at least. Angella tells herself this is the best case scenario. Either Catra is *with* Adora, or Adora will likely know where she is, and then they can get her back home safe and sound.

Anxiously, they await outside. At the ready, for any news that the team might come back with. If either of them are hurt, there are healers from Mystacor on standby. If Catra isn't with them - Adora will fill them in on her whereabouts. Then they'll have a quick strategy session for how to best plan her rescue. And Adora *doesn't* know, they will have to take a chance on a location spell that Micah had found. If -

Suddenly - Angella sees Adora, looking tired but overall alright. She, strangely, looks more at ease than she has since Catra was rescued from Beast Island. She approaches Angella and Micah first, with her head a bit bowed.

"Adora," Micah says, "What happened? Are you alright?"

"I'm okay! Everything's okay - we just, Catra had to go sign off on those flowers and she couldn't go alone, but then she got a really bad migraine again, and we fell down this *hole* ," Adora tries to explain.

"You fell down a hole?" Angella asks, incredulous, "To sign off on some *flowers?* "

"I mean, yes?" Adora tries with a wince. She looks fearful of Angella's reaction, so the Queen quickly pulls her into a hug - to assure her that it may have been *ridiculous* but it is alright.

"You cannot just leave without telling us," Angella frowns as she pulls back. "There are no flowers that are worth your safety. We have been absolutely besides ourselves with worry. This was incredibly irresponsible. And where is Catra?"

As soon as Angella says her name Catra appears, breathless in front of them. It is almost like seeing a ghost - Angella and Micah blink in surprise at the sudden appearance of the person whose absence has kept them up all night. They don't even have time to properly react before Catra is saying:

"Wait! It's not Adora's fault. She didn't do anything, alright? It was my idea to go—I just dragged her along with me. And yeah we

should've told someone—but that was my fault. So don't take it out on her."

But Angella hardly hears the words. She doesn't care about the flowers, or the hole or whatever mess they've gotten themselves into. She doesn't care whose fault it is either, because Adora *and* Catra are back. Safe. Unharmed. This was not a possibility Angella allowed herself to hope for.

Catra looks nervous - expecting *something* from Angella and Micah. But it is without hesitation that they move forward, almost on instinct, and pull her into a tight hug.

A litany of questions and relief and worry and plans for the future to avoid this from ever happening again spill from their mouths as they hold her. They only relinquish their grasp when they sense her discomfort, quickly releasing and stepping back to give her space.

"Hold up—I'm, I'm fine! I'm okay." Catra says, and Angella feels herself relax further at the confirmation. Catra is alive and unharmed and back here in Bright Moon. "I don't…I don't understand. You're not like…mad?"

Catra looks uncomfortable - perhaps a bit confused. She looks between them anxiously, still tense as though she is expecting immediate physical repercussion. Angella looks to her husband with mirrored confusion.

"Mad?" he echoes back to her.

Mad . Mad - the thought is nearly laughable, *no* . Micah does not get mad very easily, and neither does she, so long as Glimmer isn't pushing her buttons or doing something to risk her wellbeing. She has gotten mad with Glimmer before, frustrated to a boiling point - but that is because Glimmer does not *listen.* Glimmer intentionally breaks rules and shatters any necessary boundary, but she knows she is loved and cared for at the end of the day.

Catra - however. Angella cannot find it within herself to muster any anger, even less likely when she sees just how distraught Catra is. She is trying to play it off by saying, "Yeah. Thought you'd be like. Super pissed, or whatever."

"Oh, dear, no," Angella steps forward, cupping Catra's face in her hands with utmost care. Catra flinches ever so slightly, and Angella ensures to loosen her hold without pulling away entirely. Mad... *mad* is the last thing on Angella's mind. She is relieved, grateful above all else. She is also a bit pained at the blatant fear-response from Catra.

She never suspected that Catra would intentionally *leave* , much less take Adora with her. Angella isn't certain of the full story, but understands a large portion of the situation was out of their control. . She needs Catra to understand this much, to know that she is trusted - believed in. And that they do not just assume the very worst in her.

Angella gently brushes away tears as they form - as Catra works her way through a guilt-ridden apology.

"It's okay." Micah is quick to assure her, and the relief is palpable.

She seems surprised - still a bit confused, as though this is a trap of some sort.

"We know you didn't do it on purpose," Angella tells her, pulling the words from her mind that would make *her* feel most secure, "We just care about you and can't bear to see anything happen to you."

Overwhelmed, Catra says, "I didn't mean it. What I said. Yesterday. I was just…I don't know. I guess I'm not used to…this stuff. Having people care so much. It's a lot, sometimes. But I didn't mean it."

And *ah* - that explains some of the fear that wouldn't abate at their assurances. She sends her husband a look - because she has already told him as much. But her heart still aches, knowing that

Catra was afraid of him. Her husband. The very same man who is afraid of *butterflies* if they land too close to him.

"They're like spiders with wings, Angie." - She can very well hear his defense in her head, decades later.

Micah is harmless, even as the most powerful sorcerer that Mystacor has ever seen. He only ever reserves his fight for the battlefield, and even then he has difficulty holding any sort of a grudge.

The knowledge that Catra still harbors a bit of fear for him, even after all they've been through together - it only speaks to all the trauma she has endured. It is almost too much, and all Angella can really do is smile sadly at her.

"I know you didn't," Micah assures her, "And it's okay. I should've been more respectful of your space."

Catra appears to be too overwhelmed to say anything - only managing a curt nod. Angella pulls back, honoring her unspoken request for space.

The entire debacle has highlighted some of the depths to Catra's pain that Angella had not previously seen. She tries to push back her feelings of sadness at the realization - instead focus on the good. Catra is safe, no one is hurt. Perhaps now Catra can begin to understand that they only care for her safety.

And now that they *know* Catra is unharmed, Angella figures she can begin brainstorming ways to continue to ensure her wellbeing. Especially from the likes of Shadow Weaver.

Perhaps they can have some *papers* drafted by noon. They can't rush Catra or spring this question on her, but they can at least be ready.

"I guess…if you guys really want a hug, or whatever—we can do it… but just this once." Catra says - and Angella feels her heart clench at the hope in Catra's eyes.

They don’t hesitate to pull her into another hug - one she very clearly enjoys more this time. They try to convey all that they can’t say out loud quite yet in the embrace - promises of safety and protection.

It is hard for Angella to believe that, just a few short weeks ago, she had been standing on the same landing - awaiting the arrival of a different rescue team, unaware that her family was about to double in size.

Maybe being careful and calculated is a good thing - necessary traits in time of war.

But, as Angella feels Catra hug them back in kind, she decides that taking a risk every now and then is very well worth it.

so kind

Chapter Notes

> a special thank you to thegarlicbaguette for reminding me that it has, in fact, been more than a week since I posted the first chapter. something about the gun in your icon really motivated me to finish this
>
> my apologies for the wait - if you're someone who has subscribed and has gotten false hope every time I posted a new chapter of awvo instead of this fic, I have [this meme for you.]

See the end of the chapter for more notes

After Catra and Adora return from their impromptu endeavor the tension is drained from Bright Moon and replaced by a steady thrum of excited energy.

Not *too* excited though, Angella and Micah have certainly learned their lesson when it comes to making sure Catra does not over exert herself.

From what her husband has told her, it's rather apparent that the prolonged exposure to the signal on Beast Island has inflicted long-term health consequences. Angella has arranged for one of Mystacor's more specialized healers to visit following the celebration, and if they continue to scale back Catra's duties and take extra caution to –

"*Oof*," Angella registers the noise as she feels the weight of someone crashing into her. "Oh – Queen Angella, I didn't, uh – see you there."

Angella reels back to see Catra stumbling away from her. She reaches out her arms to right the girl, taking note of the guilty look upon her face. This is proof that Catra is not feeling her best – she would ordinarily never be caught off guard like this.

“See me where?” Angella questions with a raised brow, “Right here, in the hallway that is most certainly not your room. You know, the place where you’re meant to be resting right now?”

Very obviously caught, Catra stiffens at the question. Since Catra returned with Adora to Bright Moon, safe and unharmed, Micah and Angella have been extra particular about delineating between anger and concern. It seems as though the boundary between the two are rather blurry for Catra, and moments like these tend to highlight that fact.

Angella turns her gaze softer, preparing to speak again when she hears thundering footsteps approach.

“Catra!” Adora calls out, breathless and *laughing*, “Catra, did you see the look on that guard’s face when you – oh."

Adora stops just short of running into Catra, which would in turn force the girl to run back into Angella again. She halts abruptly, “Your majesty, I’m so sorry – I didn’t –“

“See me here? Yes, it would seem as though I’ve been made invisible today,” Angella finishes for her.

Catra relaxes – not entirely, but noticeably, at Adora’s arrival. It would seem as though spending some time alone together has greatly eased matters in their – friendship.

Angella is grateful for this. At least in some manners: the Alliance at large is now spared from awkward and stilted conversations between the two. As well the pining stares that would originate from either end of the war room table. *And* the library no longer needs to be fire-proofed.

However, it seems as though their reignited friendship has also sparked some additional mischief throughout the castle. Angella is no stranger to the antics that Adora would get up to with Glimmer and Bow, but it seems as though the former Horde soldiers embolden each other.

Adora takes a step forward – reflexive, as if it were muscle memory to protect Catra. She doesn't get to speak before they are interrupted by the arrival of someone *else*.

"Have you guys seen my wife?" Micah's voice echoes down the hallway as he approaches quickly. He's looking directly at Angella with a big smile on his face, "I've been looking for her all day but I just can't seem to find her."

She rolls her eyes, scoffing despite the smile on her face when he stands next to her and brushes against her. Adora and Catra look at each other before catching onto the joke and laughing lightly.

"Very funny dear," Angella says, rolling her eyes.

"Craziest thing," Micah sighs, "It's like sometimes I can still hear her voice."

Catra snorts at that, leaning forward to fake-whisper to Adora, "At least he still has his hearing."

The two giggle as Micah looks to Catra in mock offense, "Wow. You wound me."

"Well," Angella huffs before crossing her arms, "She's going to wound herself if she doesn't adhere to bedrest."

Catra wrinkles her nose in displeasure at the idea.

Micah wraps an arm around Angella's shoulder before asking, "Outsmarted the guards again, Catra?"

"It's not hard," Catra snorts. "At this point, all I have to do is distract them with something shiny." After a pause, she recognizes that Angella and Micah are still looking at her expectantly, "…and *sometimes* that shiny thing happens to be your daughter. Crying for help. Because I sent a rat illusion to her room."

"That's what you did?" Adora asks before chiding, "Catra!"

“What? She’s always bragging about not being on bed rest!” Catra defends.

Angella brings her face to her hand. That is rather funny, actually, but under no circumstance can she let Catra know that – lest she be encouraged to antagonize Glimmer further. Glimmer may have taken her on as a ‘younger’ sister, but even she has her limits.

“Catra,” Micah starts.

“You’re the one who taught me how to do that,” Catra throws back at him, crossing her arms smugly. “Besides, I wasn’t sneaking out to do anything! I was just going to gather up a few Rebellion members, go over the plan for the rest of the week leading up to the celebration, reorganize the order of events, check in with Juliet about –“

“So you were just going to work?” Angella asks, flatly.

Catra denies it breezily. “No – not at all. I was just going to, you know – double check a few things. Talk to some people. Run through some lists.”

“You’ve just listed out your duties as a party planner,” Angella points out.

“You’ve done enough work for today kid,” Micah pipes in.

“No, I haven’t,” Catra frowns, “If anything, I’ve rested too much today. There’s so much to be done, still. And we still need to meet as the Rebellion to review any new intel on the Horde to make sure they’re not planning anything.”

Angella’s frown deepens with her worry. There is a generational divide here. At Catra’s age, she was so tired of working and only sought to shirk off her duties and simply have *fun*. But it seems as though the opposite is true – Glimmer has always been so set on fighting the war, building the Rebellion. And the former Horde officer takes it a step further. Always pushing herself. Always raising the bar. There is always more work to be done.

“Tell you what,” Micah steps in, “No more work for today. *But* you don’t have to go back to your room either.”

Catra blinks – shoulders dropping from their defensive raise at the first half of Micah’s direction. “What?”

“Go,” He nods to Adora. “Both of you. Go have fun. Find Glimmer and Bow and do something fun. Play a game or watch a movie.”

Confusion twists on Catra’s face. Angella remembers. The notion of relaxing – having *fun* for the sake of it had been a lot for Adora to take in when she first arrived in Bright Moon. She suspects the blonde still struggles with it now, as well.

“That’s – but – we have stuff to do?” Catra argues, but the question in her tone speaks to her bafflement. Adora puts a hand on her shoulder.

“And that *stuff* can be done later.” Micah tells her.

“Yes. Go have fun,” Angella encourages with a soft smile, “Nothing too strenuous though!”

“Is this a trap?” Catra asks Adora, tone both serious and joking.

“I don’t think so,” Adora reports back, “But it is weird, though.”

“Get out of here before this one changes her mind,” Micah says before throwing a wink towards Angella.

Catra catches the moment, “Ew. Don’t wink at her in front of us.”

Adora tugs her away, laughing as they stumble through the hall once again. “Come on. Bet I can beat you to Glimmer’s room.”

“Pft, please. You haven’t beaten me yet, princess.” Catra elbows her before jumping ahead.

“Hey! That wasn’t fair,” Adora shouts back as she recovers and tries to catch up.

It’s a fruitless effort, Catra just snorts at her, “If you wanted fair, you wouldn’t have challenged me!”

Angella smiles as their voices fade. It is nice for the palace to feel so full of life again.

“We should’ve reminded them that the kitchen is off-limits,” Micah snaps his fingers as they exit.

“Oh trust me, the kitchen staff will make it very well known that they are no longer welcome there,” Angella barely suppresses a laugh.

“Well. Now that that’s sorted, maybe we have sometime to work on the paperwork we had mentioned earlier?” Micah proposes, squeezing her shoulder lightly. “Best to do it while Catra’s distracted. She’s a bit of a snooper.”

Angella smirks at that, “Drafted them this morning.”

Micah blinks his surprise at her, “Really? That was quick. You sure don’t waste any time.”

Angella looks at him fondly before pressing a light kiss to his cheek. “That’s only because we’ve already wasted far too much.”

All of the excitement for the celebration turned out to be very well earned. It had been the perfect day. At first, that is.

But now there is shattered glass on the ground, crumpled up papers in her husband’s hand and a lingering sense of doom.

Everything had been going so well. But, Angella reminds herself, that does not matter now. They can’t waste time reminiscing. They’ve got to come up with a plan – the Alliance can only stay on the defense for so long.

“So they’re after Catra,” she is pacing about their bedroom, mostly speaking to herself. “Do we take her somewhere? Conceal her in

Mystacor until it's safe? That's nonsense – she would get into far more trouble being alone in Mystacor than she ever could here."

She shakes her head – truly a terrible idea. Catra would hate it. But maybe members of the Rebellion could station themselves there in shifts so she won't be alone. Still, she would feel confined. Trapped. Angella can't do that to her.

Maybe Catra truly has no interest in joining their family, but Angella has made a silent vow to look after the girl. She cannot do something knowing it would cause her harm.

"What if it would save her from more harm in the long run? But that's ridiculous, we can't send Alliance members to see her. We'd expose ourselves and that would lead the Horde right to her," Angella grits her teeth.

"What does Hordak even want with her anyway? He sent her away, he exiled her. He doesn't get to – to what? Simply come back here and take her? He has no right and what of this Lonnie character? She can throw Catra through the window but then decides to offer her a shred of mercy?" Angella rants.

She spares a glance up at her husband. She hadn't been expecting him to respond, but he is looking a bit listless from where he is seated on the bed.

"Dear," She frowns, approaching him softly. She takes the papers out of his hand and places them on their nightstand. "I'm certain she didn't mean it. She's just – overwhelmed right now."

Micah simply shakes his head in response, "She's a wreck, Angie. I…something is wrong. I've got a bad feeling about this. Maybe I should go check on her again?"

He makes a move to stand, but Angella takes his hand into her own and seats herself beside him. "You've done enough for today. If you go speak to her now, it'll only upset the both of you more."

"She doesn't even see how far she's come. It's like – like she thinks she deserves this. Deserves whatever Hordak has planned for her," Micah sighs, one hand holding onto Angella's while the other rests on his head.

"You're the one always telling me we need to give her time," Angella reminds him, "This is true especially now. Look at all that's happened in one day – I can't even fathom a lifetime spent at the hand of the Horde."

"You're right – I know, you're right. I just…I promised her life would be better here," Micah laments. "And now…what if we can't protect her? What if *I* can't protect her?"

"Oh," Angella feels her heart pang as she wraps an arm around him, "She is safe with us. We'll figure something out in the morning. We will."

He simply sighs in response, taking comfort in her words.

Angella remembers the day her husband disappeared quite well. The excruciating details of the day replayed themselves in her mind endlessly before he returned home to her. She remembers how very angry she felt when they argued about whether or not he should join the Bright Moon troops in battle on that fated day; she remembers how stubborn and boorish he was in his determination to go.

And when she realized he had disobeyed her command and left for the frontlines, that anger only increased tenfold. She had prepared incredibly long reprimands for his return home, planned out a way to counter every possible justification he could muster.

But he hadn't come home that night. Or any other for the next twenty years.

Catra's vanishing act, however, is a much different story.

The girl is determined to make a liar out of Angella, it would seem. Nothing seems amiss at first – aside from the lingering tension and fear hanging in the air from the night before.

Angella and Micah are the first to arrive to the war room, which is of little surprise. But everyone else filters in on time. Catra appears to be a bit delayed, but Angella had assumed it was in an effort to avoid Micah.

When Adora enters, she looks puzzled at the empty chair next to her but doesn't say anything until a few minutes pass and it becomes clear that Catra isn't showing up.

"Where is Catra?" She asks, brows pinched in worry.

The *way* in which Adora asks will be permanently ingrained in Angella's memory. The tremble of fear in her voice – the immediate silence that falls upon the group. While no one has a response, the answer is quite clear: *not here*.

Glimmer teleports to and from Catra's room, only to report that it is empty.

They search and they find there is not a trace of Catra anywhere. It is almost like she was never even here at all, save for the debris that is left behind from yesterday.

That isn't right. If Catra were to leave, they should at least *know* she had been here in the first place. This – this was to be her *home*. She was not a prisoner here, she never was – but Angella fears maybe she had treated her like one.

Why didn't she offer Catra different options for her room – why didn't she emphasize that Catra could decorate it anyway she chose? Now that it's empty – now that she's gone, it looks like anyone could've stayed there.

And – and why didn't she ask Catra if there were a special genre of books that she was interested in? Angella could've had some loaned to the castle from far-away libraries. Why doesn't she

know if there are any special interests of Catra's – ones they could've indulged in? Now the castle is void of her, it is almost like she never set foot here at all.

It is one thing for her to be missing, but another entirely for her to have never truly been here at all.

So it is not like how it was when Micah disappeared. She does not feel anger at first, she is not reminded of him everywhere she turns. But rather, she feels failure.

It is her castle – and it's bad enough that yesterday they had been attacked; it is a reflection of her inability to hold up defense. And now, Catra has managed to run away without *any* of them noticing.

She hadn't even gotten to see a healer last night. Her injuries could worsen and she is certainly in no state to face the Horde.

When Catra's former associates – one of which had been the one to *throw* her through the window, inform them of Catra's whereabouts, Angella's fretting only grows.

It was a stupid, impulsive and foolish move for her to run off like that. Absolutely reckless – selfish of her to put the ones who love her through such worry.

But…

Angella thinks of what her husband told her last night; how pervasive Catra's self-doubt had seemed. She thinks of Catra shoving her away after she had saved her from one of the bots yesterday – the confusion and rage screwed up on her face. She couldn't fathom why Angella wanted to protect her.

And that is her greatest failure: Catra still doesn't know that they love and care for her. Of course she would be inclined to run off if she didn't *know*, didn't trust that they could work something out together.

When the time comes for the rescue group to depart, Angella is well aware that the cards are stacked against her.

She wouldn't even dare ask Micah to stay behind. She doesn't want him too either – she knows he can bring Catra back. If anyone can, it's her husband. She wouldn't jeopardize Catra's safety with her own selfishness.

Glimmer, however…Glimmer is all Angella had, for the longest time. Glimmer is – is *everything*. Glimmer is the reason Angella decided to raise the barricades. If she didn't have Glimmer, she isn't so certain she would've stayed involved in the war effort after Micah's alleged death. Glimmer was her hope, her thread, her motivation to build a safer and brighter world.

Catra is already gone. Sending Micah after her is riskier than Angella has ever allowed herself to be, but *Glimmer* crosses a line. She cannot lose Glimmer, not now. Not ever. Not after everything.

"You know she'll fight you tooth and nail until you let her go."

But her husband is right. And their daughter did nothing if not inherit Micah's stubborn nature. If Angella tries to restrain her or hold her back now, she will likely run off and get herself in a dangerous situation.

Just like her husband had before.

So Angella lets them go. She lets them all go.

"Promise me you'll come back. Promise me you'll bring them all home."

It isn't very queenly to cry, much less in a room full of people, but Angella doesn't quite have it in herself to care.

"I promise. I'm never leaving you again. I love you." Micah swears to her.

She responds with the words she was unable to say the day he disappeared, "I love you too, dear."

She should be going too. But who would protect Bright Moon in her stead?

There is a group who lingers behind. Perhaps it would be wise to stick with them, to distract herself but she excuses herself to go for a walk on the grounds.

There is comfort in being near the Moonstone, there always has been. Once she is close enough to it, Angella turns her attention back to the paper in her hand.

The note. Catra's letter.

Micah,

I have to go. I told you that I'd give this a shot but we both know I don't belong here.

Sorry for wasting your time.

-Catra

It further cements Angella's failure. Catra didn't feel like she belonged here – so much so that Catra hadn't even *addressed* the letter to her.

She knows Micah and Catra will always be closer. It is fair, it is *right*.

Ultimately, Angella knows she should have done *more*; perhaps she only succeeded in living up to the Horde's labeling of her as the cold, distant queen.

But if that is true, if that is all Catra will ever see her as, then that is fine. *When* Catra returns, if she decides to remain in Bright Moon, things will certainly change. Angella will be doubling down. Catra is going to see a healer, whether she likes it or not. There will be no further war planning or strategizing or practicing of magic until they can get her migraines figured out. There will be no bargaining or having fun with her friends until she is healthy and well rested again.

Maybe Angella couldn't be a warm, parental figure for Catra. Not like her husband. But she will make damned certain that Catra is cared for and kept safe.

"Um, Angella?" A timid voice calls out.

Angella would prefer to be left alone right now. She turns around to greet her unexpected visitor – but the look of displeasure melts off of her face once she realizes who it is.

"Oh," She blinks in surprise, "Frosta. Hello."

"Hi," Frosta responds back, looking a bit uncomfortable. It is rather out of character for her, given how boisterous she normally is. But, Angella supposes this is their first time ever interacting privately. Perhaps Frosta feels a bit small when she is not interacting with fellow princesses. "Are you…alright?"

At the question, Angella realizes how tightly she'd been gripping Catra's letter in her hand. She relaxes immediately, dropping her shoulders before neatly tucking the note away. "Ah. Yes. I'm fine. Though, I appreciate your concern."

"Oh. It's just that you walked out of there really quick," Frosta observes. "Are you mad at Catra?"

Angella is taken aback by the brashness of the question. But Frosta has always been rather direct. "I…"

Realizing her overstep, Frosta backtracks, "Sorry. I shouldn't have –"

“No, you’re quite alright. I – I’m afraid I don’t know what to feel right now,” Angella informs her, “But I suppose I can decide on an emotion once everyone returns safely.”

“You think they’ll be okay?” Frosta asks, clearly uncertain.

And – ah, yes. It makes sense now. Frosta has sought her out for assurance.

“They will be. They have to be. Micah promised me as much,” Angella tells her. She *is* worried, but she can’t let it show to the young princess.

“Okay,” Frosta nods, pausing for a moment before saying. “But what if…*I’m* mad at Catra?”

“That is fair.” Angella concludes, holding her hands behind her back as she regards the princess with interest. “You’re allowed to be.”

“I mean - she *lied* to us! She left us!” Frosta’s anger is evident in her voice, “I knew she was from the Horde but I *trusted* her.”

Angella nods thoughtfully. “I trusted her as well. And, while I am weary of the choice’s she’s made, I still do.”

“You do? How?”

“That is the thing about trust, Frosta. It is easy to trust someone when times are easy. But such trust is only true if it holds steady when the world shifts, when the odds are stacked against us.”

After allowing Frosta a moment to digest her words, Angella adds, “Catra is not the Horde officer we once knew. I believe that she has changed for the better.”

Frosta nods, before looking out past the Moonstone – into the horizon where an uncertain future awaits. Her gaze is steely and determined, “Then I do too.”

Despite the heaviness in her heart, Angella smiles.

"Mom!"

Glimmer's voice is frantic, eyes filled with unshed tears. She doesn't even have a moment to process her relief at the sight of her daughter being alright before the fear creeps in.

"Glimmer," Angella frowns, "What's the matter? What's going on?"

She doesn't get a response though – Glimmer throws herself into her mother's arms, muffled sobs and choking out the words *Dad* and *Catra* intermittently.

"Queen Angella," Adora is right behind her daughter. Her face is grim and she looks rather battle worn. "We – we found Catra. But her and Micah are – really hurt. They're in Mystacor right now."

Alarmed, Angella pulls back from Glimmer. "We have to go. Now."

Glimmer has enough energy to teleport them to Mystacor. A turbulent mixture of fear and confusion swell within Angella once they arrive. She is having trouble making sense of this, parsing out any of the details that Glimmer and Adora frantically relay her.

She notices her husband laying on a gurney and surrounded by healers. But her attention is soon drawn away by Bow's worried voice calling out, "Catra?"

Catra.

Angella looks at the girl and exhales a great sigh of relief. She is here – she is *alive.* But she is swaying in Bow's grip, exhaustion pulling at her features. She looks…terrible. Bruised and blooded, clothing torn and ash across her face. Angella lurches forward, reaching for Catra when the last semblance of consciousness leaves her body.

She falls limp, but Adora is one step ahead – having clearly recognized what was happening before anyone else, and catches her easily.

Where are the healers – and who exactly let Catra work herself up into such a state? Angella's nostrils flare as she joins Adora's side, demanding assistance. A few healers scramble to get Catra situated into a room, but Angella's heart does not stop pounding in her chest. Not as her daughter and her friends attempt to fill her in on everything that transpired in the Fright Zone.

An orderly very thinly accuses Angella of not being responsive to Catra's malnourishment and over-exertion. Apparently they view Angella as her caretaker. Even if no one else does.

They inform her that her wounds will take longer to heal, a consequence of running her body ragged.

Her jaw ticks as she watches over Micah. Her eyes continue to fall to the orange and gold scarring on his upper bicep. It is impressive magic. Angella hasn't quite seen anything like it before.

She has faith in her sister-in-law. And she knows Micah will make good on his promise. He will return to her. There is no other choice.

She is not angry with him. Not really. Not with Catra, either. Angella is more worried than anything.

They should've kept a closer eye on her. They were just so worried about hovering too much and they trusted Catra would at least take care of herself to basic levels.

When Glimmer arrives and Bow declares he is dragging Adora back to Bright Moon for a shower, Angella decides to give her daughter some time alone with her father. She does not want Catra to be alone, either, so she decides to stand post in her room.

Maybe she also needs to see her again; to know that she is okay.

Also…she needs assurance that Catra won't run off again. Not before they can speak. It is a simple bit of tethering magic, but it will keep her here regardless.

She is a bit more cleaned up than before. Bandaged with her wounds dressed. But up close, Angella can see the bags underneath her eyes, the taut nature of her skin. Catra's pain is visible, and Angella's heart aches at the sight.

Catra has not been resting easy according to Adora and the healers. She groans, sweat beading on her forehead while she turns in the bed.

Very gently, Angella brushes her wild hair out of her face. Her forehead is warm, she notes with a frown. The healers had mentioned the possibility of a fever. There is a washcloth and basin at the side of Catra's bed. Gently, Angella wrings out the water and places the damp rag across her face.

It seems to work in soothing her, if only marginally. "There. You'll be alright," Angella tells her.

Glimmer was thankfully never sick very much as a child, but she'd fallen victim to the flu at least once every other year. Angella is a tried and true veteran at this game. Catra groans as Angella adjusts the cloth. "Shh. It's alright now."

The last time they were in a similar position – it had been their first time officially meeting face-to-face.

Angella could nearly scoff at her past-self. She had no idea what she was in for; how much the broken Horde soldier would come to mean to her and her family.

"Everything will be alright," Angella comforts, "You're safe now. We'll get you taken care of."

And maybe Angella herself is just imagining it, but she could swear Catra relaxes the slightest bit.

Returning with Catra to Bright Moon goes better than anticipated. As had their conversation.

Angella understands Catra a bit better now, understands how badly the girl wants things to go back to the way they were before. She believes Catra had written the note before they became acquainted..

But, despite Catra's desire for normalcy, Angella is afraid that won't happen so soon. There is a hole in the castle without Micah here. And while she is optimistic about her husband's health, Angella is not immune to worry.

She goes to the library, she reads through some of the recent books he had laid out – clearly intending to go through them following the celebration. It brings her a strange sense of comfort.

But she hears something. The slightest shuffle. It comes as no surprise. She was aware that someone would be keeping an eye on her.

"I know you're there," Angella says with a sigh, "So why don't you step out of the shadows and give me your best explanation as to *why* you've left your room?"

Catra approaches her slowly, sluggish and drained still. Angella is well aware that, had Catra been feeling better, she could've easily evaded notice. Actually, Angella is fairly certain that Catra *still* could've evaded notice even in her current state.

She wanted to be found.

Catra doesn't offer any explanation, which is just as well. Angella stands silently, arm laid across Catra's shoulder to assist her in walking back to her room.

Instead of protesting the help, Catra states, "I'm tired."

Her voice is groggy – any other situation and Angella might laugh.

"Mhm. And I imagine coming out of your room to find me didn't make you feel more rested somehow?" Angella poses.

She shakes her head a bit petulantly when they walk into her room. "You haven't come by." Catra accuses.

Angella feels her heart twist at that. "That's where you're wrong, dear. Every time I've come by, you've been asleep."

Catra crawls into her bed, "Yea,h right."

Angella *is* right. But that is not the point. "It's time for more rest."

"You shouldn't be alone," Catra informs her as she lays down onto her pillow, eyes closed before they even come in contact with the bed. "Alone is bad for thinking."

Angella smiles down at her, taking the blanket to drape over her, "You're not alone now, Catra."

"Was talking about you," Catra mutters, but it doesn't even hold an eighteenth of the fire her voice normally does.

Pulling up a chair next to Catra's bed, Angella is grateful that they have each other.

"Told you I'd come back."

Angella isn't too surprised that those are her husband's first words to her upon waking up.

She is more than glad to return the favor after Catra presents the signed adoption papers back to them. "*I told you she would*."

But Bow raises a great point – now that Catra is officially part of the royal family, there does need to be some formal sort of

celebration. One that is not ruined with any Horde debauchery.

After Hordak and Shadow Weaver are kept prisoners in the Kingdom of the Snows and the war is over, Angella has quite a bit of time on her hands to plan the ceremony.

Or at least, she *would* have time to do so. If her husband could restrain himself from bursting into her study and scaring the daylight out of her.

Her breath catches in her throat and she immediately drops all of the papers she had been studying. "*Micah*, dear. We've been through this. There are doors here. At the very least you need to knock to give me somehwat a warning." She admonishes.

"Hide. Everything." He tells her breathlessly, "Catra's coming."

Angella's eyes widen – her husband's hurriedness is not unbidden. Catra *cannot* find out about this coronation ceremony or she will only protest to insufferable amounts. Angella wouldn't plan out something Catra wouldn't enjoy, but that doesn't mean the girl won't still fight it tooth and nail.

Angella makes quick work of stashing the papers away, only slightly surprised when Glimmer teleports into the room mere seconds later.

She glances between her husband and her daughter, amusement playing at her features as she folds her hands together and rests them under her chin. "You've legally had two two daughters for less than thirty days. Do you mean to tell me you're already mixing them up?"

Glimmer opens her mouth and speaks so quickly that Angella does not catch a single word of it.

"Just you wait," Micah says to her with a grin. Initially, Angella had been worried there was a problem of some sort, but the mirth on his face tells her that this is going to be, at minimum, an entertaining interruption.

Catra appears moments later – disheveled and out of breath. She must be counting her lucky stars that she'd been cleared for all physical activity a week ago, or else Angella would be giving her a mouthful right now.

"Don't listen to her!" Catra demands, pointing an accusatory finger at Glimmer. "She's crazy!"

"Listen to her?" Angella tilts her head to the side in interest, "Catra, I can hardly understand her. What have the two of you gotten yourselves into now?"

"Catra said she loves us!" Glimmer says, excitement beaming in her voice, even *louder* as she repeats it, "Catra said she loves us!"

"I did not!" Catra refutes, making a move to lunge at Glimmer.

Micah stops her by extending his arm out. He catches Angella's eye with a mischievous smile. There is a dramatic moment of silence – anticipation hanging in the air, before Micah declares, "She said, and I'm quoting here: 'you losers are lucky I love you.'"

"Told you!" Glimmer says triumphantly.

Catra turns her assault on him then and he barely manages to hold her off with his own laughter. "Hey, kid –"

"Hm. To be loved and called a loser in the same sentence," Angella smiles, "What prompted such a heartfelt sentiment?"

"I told her about Family Game Night!" Glimmer is still yelling, "And she agreed to it!"

With a huff, Catra pushes Micah away. She looks at Angella before pointedly looking away and crossing her arms, "So what if I did? It's not a big deal." She mutters something unintelligible – at least from where Angella sits.

"I'm sorry, what was that dear?" Angella asks, a patient smile on her face.

"It's not a big deal?" Catra offers, as if anyone in the room will let her off the hook so easily.

"No I mean the second half, the part you uttered under your breath?" Angella questions.

Catra rolls her eyes, dropping her crossed arms and avoids eye contact with all of them. "I said *obviously* I love you guys."

Glimmer squeals with excitement at Angella's side.

Micah smiles fondly at Catra as her face turns red. "Proud of you."

She groans as he hugs her and tries so very hard to fight the smile on her face, "Gross. See, this is what I wanted to avoid. Can we go now? Clearly Angella is busy doing – I don't know. Whatever she does, now."

"Hm, not so fast," Angella says with a smirk, standing up from her desk and walking in front of Catra. "That's not how we do things in this family."

Catra eyes her suspiciously, but long gone is the hardened distrust that she regarded Angella with.

Angella places her hands on Catra's shoulders, leaning down to press a kiss to her forehead before saying, "We love you too, dear. *Obviously*."

"Yeah, obviously!" Glimmer echoes behind her, launching herself between her parents to wrap them all in a hug.

Catra grumbles her grievances at Glimmer, but reciprocates the hug willingly.

There is but a single moment of peace before Glimmer pulls away first. "You *love* us. Oh my god, I have to tell Bow and Adora you finally said it!"

She makes a break for the door then, which is foolish, really. She should've teleported, because Catra jumps on her and demands, "Don't you dare!"

"Girls," Angella sighs as they continue to tussle in the hallway. Her and Micah stand side by side in the doorframe. "Do not break anything or *each other*."

They ignore her.

"What's the matter? Afraid everyone is going to find out you're secretly a softie?" Glimmer taunts, despite how she has absolutely no leverage to do so.

"I take it back," Catra snarks, "I can't stand you!"

Glimmer teleports them just a few meters down the hall, just enough to disorient Catra and gain the upper hand as she laughs. "Oh *Boooow*…" She sing-songs, "Guess what?"

"I do *not* love Arrow Boy so don't even try it," Catra huffs.

Their skirmish continues down the hallways, clamoring continuing as the guards eye them curiously. They know better than to intervene – they know of the consequence.

The hallways echo with their chaos. It is nothing like how it had been a few months ago, Glimmer and Angella living together in quiet, if occasionally tense, harmony.

It is loud and rambunctious.

Micah wraps an arm around Angella's waist and she leans against his shoulder with a smile.

Her world is alive again.

Chapter End Notes

.....I do have 2 one-shots I'd like to complete before considering this series done but I'm making no promises on when those will appear

End Notes

the second chapter will just be scenes + bonus moments from the second half of exile, hopefully will be posted by the end of next week!

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!